do not readily decompose, and their lateral planes present a perpendicular wall.'[1] William Sykes went on to point out how these rock walls made excellent barriers but also provided convenient facades into which man-made caves could be burrowed.

The Western Ghats extend north and south for about 990 miles (1600 kilometres), and, despite that word *ghat*, which also carries the meaning of 'pass' or 'crossing', there is only one weak link in the chain: the Palakkad Gap, a low pass between the Nilgiri and Anaimalai hills (see Map 2).



The Palakkad Gap, as painted in watercolours across two pages of an album of drawings by Lieutenant-Fireworker Thomas Cussans in 1820.

Until the building of the railways in the nineteenth century the Palakkad Gap provided the only significant east–west corridor though the mountains. As such, it was almost certainly the main portal through which early humans, having hitherto stuck to the coastal strips that had made possible the eastward migration of *Homo sapiens* out of East Africa, first penetrated into the Deccan interior. They did so by following the Nila River (also known as the Punnani or Bharathappuzha) upstream. Proof of this drive inland comes from the extraordinary number of megalithic burial sites, in the form of granite slab cists, stone-lined burial chambers, urn burials and worked stone tools, found beside the Nila and its main tributaries.

But the Palakkad Gap also provided a crossing point in both directions, so it later became increasingly important strategically as trade routes began to develop in historical